government is determined to get rid of those bases—up to, in the extreme case, of bombing them, since, I repeat, they pose a great threat to the security of the USA," read Dobrynin's cable to Moscow recapitulating Robert Kennedy's words. "But in response to the bombing of these bases, in the course of which Soviet specialists might suffer, the Soviet government will undoubtedly respond with the same against us, somewhere in Europe. A real war will begin, in which millions of Americans and Russians will die."[13]

According to Dobrynin's report, he was the first to raise the issue of American missiles in Turkey after Kennedy explained his brother's official proposal to dismantle the Soviet missile bases and remove nuclear weapons from Cuba in exchange for an American pledge of noninvasion. As Dobrynin recalled decades later, at that moment he still had no instructions from Moscow on how to deal with the Americans, nor even a complete copy of Khrushchev's letter proposing a Cuban-Turkish swap—he had to rely on Western broadcasts. Still, now that Moscow's official backing of such a deal was clear to him, he decided to address the issue.[14]

According to Dobrynin, "Robert Kennedy was ready with an answer" to his question about Turkey. What we know today is that Kennedy was in fact waiting for an opportunity to discuss the missiles in Turkey. "If that is the only obstacle to achieving the regulation I mentioned earlier, then the president doesn't see any insurmountable difficulties in resolving this issue," Robert told Dobrynin. "The greatest difficulty for the president is the public discussion of the issue of Turkey," he continued, explaining to Dobrynin how his brother proposed to resolve the issue. "Formally the deployment of missile bases in Turkey was done by a special decision of the NATO Council. To announce now a unilateral decision by the president of the USA to withdraw missile bases from Turkey—this would damage the entire structure of NATO and the US position as the leader of NATO, where, as the Soviet government knows very well, there are many arguments. In short, if such a decision were announced now it would seriously tear apart NATO. However, President Kennedy is ready to come to agree[ment] on that question with N. S. Khrushchev, too. I think that in order to withdraw these bases from Turkey, we need 4–5 months."